

active buyers in the valley; none wanted this place. Too remote. Too dry. Too hard to manage. Too unproductive.

“Aha!” we told ourselves. “They don’t see the value. OK, it’s not a great ranch from a productive standpoint. The cows are too skinny. The climate is too harsh. It’s too far from the markets. But, boy, what views! Someday, people will pay big money for those views.”

We imagined ourselves having discovered what others had missed. This might not be the greatest ranch in the world, but what a great place to come to visit. If we ever wanted to sell, we were sure we could poke some other gringo in the eye for at least as much as we paid.

It was then we learned the meaning of the word *ilusionado* in Spanish. Or more precisely, *desilusionado*. We had been *ilusionado* when we bought. Later, we were *desilusionado*.

It turned out that everyone was right. The ranch is too far, too high, too dry, and almost impossible to manage.

Our ranch is so dry that one day, cattlemen came up from the pampas and asked: “What do your cattle eat?”

We told them that we’re creating a new breed of low-fat cow we call “sand-fed beef.”

They laughed and shook their heads.

And then we wondered if we’d lose the farm altogether. A group of locals—descended, they said, from the original tribes who owned the place—tried to take it over! They claimed it had been stolen from their ancestors 500 years before. They wanted it back!

One challenge after another. But we’ve held on.

It’s still in our hands. Still losing money. And still a pleasure to visit.

What was the point of that little anecdote?

Just that we all become *ilusionado* from time to time. We want to believe the sales pitches. We want to believe we see an angle others have missed.

We’re usually wrong.

The best investment is one that no one tries to sell you. And that no salesman represents. Generally, you want to be the neighbor who buys the good bottomland, the person who knows more about it than any other buyer and who realizes what the value really is. That’s why you want to be in